Touch

By Toni Press-Coffman

INTRODUCTION

Kyle Kalke, an astronomer since childhood, a high school "science nerd," falls in love with flamboyant, outspoken, openhearted Zoe, who—astonishingly—loves him back. But when she is kidnapped and murdered, Kyle searches for answers in an attempt to understand the meaning of Zoe's life and ultimately the meaning of her death. Touch by Toni Press-Coffman

KYLE: I was taking physics, and that's where I saw her for the first time. She looked into the room. Peeked in. The teacher asked her whether he could help her, and then she stepped in, looking all around the room. Zoe had huge eyes. Gigantic. As she looked around the room, her eyes reminded me of the heavens.

She fixed her glance on me for a second or maybe two seconds, only it felt like much longer. Then she said, "I am so in the wrong room," and turned around and walked out the door. I didn't think. Which had rarely - maybe never - happened before. I literally jumped to my feet and went after her. Zoe caused me to be late to class for the first time in my life. Then it was every day. It was impossible to stop looking at her once I started. I would come to school early, I would find her, and I would look at her until the bell. I dreamed of her at night and did nothing but look at her at school.

We got married the Christmas after high school graduation. December 22. Winter solstice. Our decision to marry made our parents insane. Mine told me I didn't have to marry the first young woman I dated and her folks just thought I was - odd. We had our honeymoon in New York City. The honeymoon was beautiful

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beyond imagining.

We both went to college. Zoe majored in - umm.. She kept changing her mind. *(He thinks)* I can't - I can't remember what she settled on. *(Upset)* Why can't I remember that? *(Composes himself.)* I majored in astronomy.

A month before our sixth anniversary, she and I gave Thanksgiving. [Zoe] was sitting on a big red pillow in our living room, her cheeks were red too because she'd drunk quite a bit of wine. People kissed us as they left. Her mom kissed each of her cheeks and Zoe threw back her head and through this completely radiant smile told her mother, "You make a great me." Then she said "I'm so happy you realize how I feel about Kyle now." *(Beat; it's starting to get him, but he wards it off.)* By ten or so, it was just us and Bennie and Serena. Zoe decided had to have this coffee drink she liked to make, with Triple Sec and whipping cream, only we had no whipping cream, and Zoe said she'd run down to twenty-four hour market to get some. Serena told Zoe to wait, she'd go with her, but Zoe said no, Serena should stay, she'd be right back. *(Beat)* She grabbed her purse. *(Beat)* She put on her black leather hat. *(Beat)* She kissed me. *(Beat; tears come up)* Thank God. *(He composes himself)* She left. *(Kyle pauses for a long time)*

Forty-five minutes after she left, her sister asked - umm - how far away the market was anyway. Forty-five minutes. Which is impossible. My wife went to the grocery store to buy one item, I let her go, late at night, by herself – and she's gone forty-five minutes and even then I don't notice. Her sister notices. Which is unforgivable. Because that is a long goddamn time, and in that time - I could have - [done something to help her]. I should have – [gone to the grocery store myself.]

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After that -- after Serena noticed Zoe wasn't coming home - I was delirious with worry. I already knew. Maybe not that she was dead – but I knew that she was at least badly hurt because I knew Zoe. *(Beat)* I knew she would not stay away and not call. I knew she was hurt and I knew I could have gone to the grocery store.

The police wouldn't look for her until she was missing for twenty-four hours. A detective asked me who she might have – he said "split with." *(Registers this, tries to calm down)* Who might your wife, the person you care about most in the world, the only woman you've EVER loved, have "split with"? *(Beat)* I tried to explain that Zoe did not mince words, Zoe always said exactly what was on her mind, no exceptions whatsoever, including, "Sorry, Kyle, I love somebody else, I'm leaving." That's what she would have done, she would not have just -- "split." My wife would not have done that."

I told the detective about Zoe. I talked and talked and talked and talked. *(pleading with the cop)* Our car is still in the parking lot, doesn't that tell you something? It told him that whoever she left me for picked her up in the supermarket parking lot. Nothing registered. He was going to wait twenty-four hours.

(After a pause) I didn't sleep until much later. When she died. Which I didn't know at the time, but my body would not shut down until hers did. Then I slept.

(the phone rings. Twice. Three times). (On the phone) Yes? *(Beat)* Yes, this is Zoe Kalke's home. I'm her husband. *(Quickly)* Did you find my wife? *(Kyle listens for a beat. Then . . .)* Sixteen days after Thanksgiving . . . . a man's dog found Zoe's bag buried in his yard. Up at the southeast corner of the Navajo reservation. Um. . .

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He searched and found -- just beyond his property -- a pile a rocks. *(Beat)* The Navajo believe it will harm them to come in contact with a dead body, and – and he sensed she was there but he didn't want to uncover her for – uh – spiritual reasons. (Beat) He thought of involving the police but – well, the tribal police are Navajo and he didn't want them to have to - touch her. *(Beat)* So he thought if he called her number, that might help him decide what was best. I told him I'd be there immediately.

She has no clothes on. Is she smiling? Could it be just – a – an – anomaly? Could it have happened after she died? Zoe, are you smiling? . . . . . Who killed her? Random chaos – entropy – like a black hole – always increases. The supermarket swallowed Zoe. Or maybe her car swallowed her. Maybe her heart. Maybe Zoe got swallowed by her great big, ever-expanding, loaded-with-the-spirit heart. I prefer not to think about the police and their investigation. I prefer to think about black holes. I'm not confident they will find the men who hurt Zoe.

[But] Then, in the summer, early in July, the police arrested two men for rape, and when the police searched their van, they found pictures. (Beat) Of Zoe. *(Beat)* I suppose I should be grateful that these criminals were so stupid. The police called me at work, and I went down there. *(Beat)* She was alive in the pictures. *(Beat)* She didn't look hurt, but she wasn't smiling. My wife was raped and murdered. The police caught them. The men who killed Zoe. They confessed.

I talked to each of them separately. Each one could have said no, but each agreed to speak to me. Which I didn't understand at first, but now I think it was Zoe. Zoe was smiling. Zoe was telling me, I am dying. I'm dying, Kyle. That's what my life is now. I'm dying. *(Kyle stops, and closes his eyes and breathes. He opens his*

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eyes) The first one said no, he didn't notice she was smiling. *(Beat)* She said if one of them would stay there with her until she died, she would like that. *(Beat, he can hardly say this).* She would be grateful. *(Beat)* Zoe hated to be alone. This kid was spooked by that. He told me he didn't know why, but he grabbed her purse and ran with it. He had killed before, but he didn't want to be there when Zoe died. So the other one stayed with her. *(Kyle closes his eyes and breathes. His measured breath becomes more shallow, becomes panting. He opens his eyes).*

When he came into the visiting room, he sat down, rigid, and fixed his gaze on me. He didn't speak. *(He takes a deep breath, like he did then).* I asked him if he noticed she was smiling, and he said yes. *(Pause, like he's waiting for more, like he did then)* I asked him was she scared, and he said yes. *(Beat)* But as she faded, she seemed less and less so. I asked if she spoke my name. He said no. He said he didn't want to piss me off, but she was "one weird chick." Because, as she lay dying, she mumbled something about the stars. (*Kyle closes his eyes and breathes. He opens his eyes abruptly).* She died . . . She died. He said you're crazy too, buddy. I banged the telephone on the Plexiglas separating me from him. I said did you touch her? Did you touch her while she was dying? DID YOU TOUCH HER? And there it was. He flinched. He looked at me. *(Beat)* She – uh -- she reached her hand out to me, he said. She reached for me. *(Beat)* Yeah. I let her touch me. *(Kyle stops, cries, breathes, waits).*

I said – I said – we met in my physics class.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Toni Press-Coffman
ISBN: 978-0822220558
Publisher: Dramatists Play Service, Inc.
Date (Month/Year): Jan 2005

AWARDS

2003 National Qualifier
2005 National Qualifier
2007 National Qualifier
2009 National Qualifier
2012 National Qualifier
2013 National Qualifier
MN State Qualifier

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